# PLEXUS: MERN OAuth2 Social Login System with AI-Powered Recommendations

**Project Report**

## Executive Summary

**PLEXUS** is a full-stack web application that demonstrates a production-ready implementation of OAuth2 social authentication combined with an AI-powered recommendation system. The project implements the MERN (MongoDB, Express.js, React, Node.js) stack with a cyberpunk-themed user interface and integrates multiple third-party services including Google and Facebook OAuth providers, TMDB, Spotify, Google Books APIs, and Google Gemini for AI-generated insights. The application successfully addresses critical requirements including OAuth2 Authorization Code flow with PKCE, secure JWT-based session management with httpOnly cookies, provider account linking/unlinking, role-based access control, and comprehensive security measures against common web vulnerabilities.

## 1. Introduction

### 1.1 Project Overview

PLEXUS represents a comprehensive full-stack solution for implementing OAuth2 social login authentication in modern web applications. The project extends beyond basic authentication by integrating an intelligent recommendation system that provides personalized suggestions for movies, music, and books. Built on the MERN architecture, PLEXUS demonstrates industry best practices in security, scalability, and user experience design.

### 1.2 Problem Statement & Objectives

The project addresses the challenge of implementing secure OAuth2 authentication with support for multiple identity providers while maintaining minimal user friction during onboarding. Key objectives include:

- Implementing OAuth2 with Google (using PKCE) and Facebook (using state + nonce) providers
- Creating a secure session management system using JWT tokens stored in httpOnly cookies
- Providing seamless provider linking for users with the same email across different OAuth providers
- Building a role-based access control system supporting user and admin roles
- Integrating an AI-powered recommendation engine that respects user privacy and provides personalized suggestions

- Maintaining comprehensive security hardening throughout the application

### 1.3 Technology Stack

**Frontend:** React 19.2.0, Material-UI (MUI) 7.3.5, React Router DOM 7.9.5, Axios 1.13.2
**Backend:** Node.js with Express 5.1.0, MongoDB with Mongoose 8.19.2
**Authentication:** JSON Web Tokens (JWT), OAuth 2.0 with PKCE
**Recommendation Service:** Separate microservice architecture, Supabase for data persistence
**External APIs:** Google OAuth, Facebook OAuth, TMDB, Spotify, Google Books, Google Gemini

## 2. OAuth2 Implementation Architecture

### 2.1 Google OAuth2 with PKCE

The application implements Google OAuth2 using the Authorization Code flow enhanced with Proof Key for Code Exchange (PKCE), a critical security extension that protects against authorization code interception attacks. PKCE eliminates the need for a static client secret in the public client (browser) by introducing dynamically generated cryptographic values.

**PKCE Flow Implementation:**

The frontend generates a 56-character random code verifier during the authentication initiation. This code verifier is transformed into a code challenge by computing its SHA-256 hash and encoding it in base64url format. The code challenge is transmitted to Google's authorization server along with additional security parameters including a random state value for CSRF protection and a nonce for replay attack prevention.

The authorization request includes `access_type=offline` to request a refresh token and `prompt=consent` to ensure users see the consent screen even if previously authenticated. When the user grants authorization, Google redirects to the application's callback URI with an authorization code.

The backend exchanges this authorization code for tokens by sending the original code verifier in the token exchange request. Google validates the code verifier by hashing it and comparing against the stored code challenge. Only the legitimate application possessing the original code verifier can complete this exchange, preventing attackers from using intercepted authorization codes.

**Security Mechanisms:**

- **PKCE (RFC 7636):** Prevents authorization code interception by requiring a secret that cannot be exposed in the redirect URL
- **State Parameter:** CSRF protection by verifying the state value returned matches what was sent
- **Nonce Parameter:** Replay attack prevention by ensuring each authentication session uses a unique nonce
- **Secure Token Storage:** Refresh tokens are stored exclusively in httpOnly cookies with SameSite: strict configuration

## 2.2 Facebook OAuth2 Implementation

Facebook OAuth2 follows the Authorization Code flow without PKCE support, as Facebook's implementation does not yet support this extension. The flow maintains security through state and nonce parameters while relying on HTTPS for transport security.

The authorization request directs users to Facebook's OAuth dialog with client ID, redirect URI, state, and nonce parameters. After user authentication and consent, Facebook redirects to the callback URI with an authorization code. The backend exchanges this code for an access token by making a POST request to Facebook's token endpoint.

Following token acquisition, the application fetches user profile data from Facebook's Graph API, which provides email, name, and profile picture information. The state parameter is validated on the callback to ensure the response originated from the legitimate authorization server.

## 2.3 Provider Linking and Account Unification

A critical feature of PLEXUS is automatic provider linking for users with identical email addresses across providers. This prevents account fragmentation and provides users a unified identity across authentication methods.

**Linking Mechanism:**

When a user authenticates via any OAuth provider, the system performs a case-insensitive email lookup in the MongoDB user collection. If a user with matching email exists but is authenticated via a different provider, the system automatically links both providers to the same user account. This linking occurs transparently without requiring user confirmation, simplifying the user experience while maintaining security.

The user schema maintains separate fields for each provider's identifier and email:

- `providers.googleId` - Google's unique user identifier
- `providers.googleEmail` - Email from Google profile
- `providers.facebookId` - Facebook's unique user identifier
- `providers.facebookEmail` - Email from Facebook profile

**Unlinking Constraints:**

The system enforces a critical constraint that prevents users from unlinking their last remaining provider, ensuring users maintain at least one authentication method. This prevents account lockout scenarios where users lose all access.

# 3. Secure Session Management

### 3.1 Dual Token Architecture

PLEXUS implements a sophisticated token management strategy using two complementary JWT tokens, each with distinct purposes, expiration times, and storage mechanisms:

**Access Token:**

- Payload contains user identification (id, email, name, role)
- Short lifespan of 15 minutes minimizes exposure window if compromised
- Stored in React component state (memory) rather than persistent storage
- Transmitted via Authorization header on API requests
- Vulnerable to XSS attacks if exposed but limited by short expiration

**Refresh Token:**

- Same payload structure as access token
- Extended 7-day expiration for seamless user experience
- Stored exclusively in httpOnly cookies with secure, SameSite: strict flags
- Protected from XSS attacks as JavaScript cannot access httpOnly cookies
- Automatically sent by browser on same-origin requests
- Used only for obtaining new access tokens at `/auth/refresh` endpoint

This architecture balances security and usability: httpOnly cookies prevent XSS attacks while short-lived access tokens limit the impact of token compromise.

### 3.2 Token Refresh Flow

When an access token expires during a user's session, the application detects the 401 Unauthorized response and automatically initiates token refresh without user intervention.

The Axios interceptor middleware layer intercepts all 401 responses, extracts the refresh token from httpOnly cookies, and makes a POST request to the `/auth/refresh` endpoint. The backend validates the refresh token signature and expiration, then issues a new access token with the same user payload.

Upon successful refresh, the backend sets new cookies with updated expiration times and returns the new access token to the frontend. The interceptor automatically retries the original failed request with the new credentials. If refresh token validation fails (expired or invalid), the user is logged out and redirected to the login page.

### 3.3 Security Configuration

**Cookie Configuration:**

- `httpOnly: true` - Prevents JavaScript access, protecting against XSS attacks
- `secure: true` - Ensures transmission only over HTTPS in production

- `sameSite: 'strict'` - Prevents cookies from being sent with cross-site requests, protecting against CSRF attacks
- `maxAge: 604800000` (7 days) - Automatic expiration after 7 days

**Token Secrets:**
The application uses separate cryptographic secrets for access and refresh tokens, preventing attackers from using a compromised access token secret to forge refresh tokens and extend their access indefinitely.

## 4. Security Architecture

### 4.1 Authentication Security

PLEXUS implements multi-layered security mechanisms addressing diverse threat vectors:

**Transport Security:**
All communication occurs over HTTPS in production, providing encryption for credentials and tokens in transit. The development environment uses HTTP with clear documentation for production HTTPS requirements.

**CSRF Protection:**
The application implements CSRF protection using the `csurf` middleware for state-changing operations. CSRF tokens are generated for each session and validated on all POST, PUT, and DELETE requests except those exempt (like OAuth callbacks that use state parameter validation).

**Input Validation:**
All user inputs are validated using `express-validator` with strict schemas, preventing injection attacks and malformed data processing. Mongoose schemas provide additional database-level validation.

**Rate Limiting:**
The `express-rate-limit` middleware enforces two rate-limiting policies:

- General routes: 100 requests per 15 minutes per IP address
- Authentication routes: 10 requests per 30 minutes per IP address

This prevents brute-force attacks on login and token refresh endpoints while allowing legitimate users normal access patterns.

### 4.2 API Security

**CORS Configuration:**
Cross-Origin Resource Sharing is carefully configured with `credentials: true` to allow cookie transmission only from legitimate frontend origins, preventing unauthorized cross-origin requests.

**JWT Verification Middleware:**
Protected routes require valid JWT tokens in the Authorization header. The verification middleware validates the token signature using the JWT secret, checks expiration, and rejects invalid tokens with 401 Unauthorized responses.

**Admin Authorization Middleware:**
Endpoints requiring admin privileges verify both JWT validity and user role, returning 403 Forbidden if the user lacks admin permissions.

### 4.3 Data Security

**Provider Secrets Management:**
All OAuth provider credentials (client IDs, client secrets), JWT secrets, database URIs, and API keys are stored as environment variables, never hardcoded. This prevents accidental exposure through version control and allows different configurations per deployment environment.

**Minimal PII Storage:**
The application stores only essential user information (email, name, provider IDs) and avoids storing sensitive data like passwords (OAuth-only) or payment information.

**Database Security:**
MongoDB connection strings use authentication credentials, and the application connects to MongoDB Atlas with encrypted connections.

## 5. Frontend Architecture

### 5.1 Component Structure

The React frontend is organized with clear separation of concerns into logical directories:

**API Layer (`src/api/`):**
Contains Axios instances for public and private (authenticated) API calls. The public instance handles unauthenticated requests, while the private instance includes automatic token refresh logic.

**Components (`src/components/`):**
Reusable UI components including `ProtectedRoute` for route protection, `NeonGrid` for cyberpunk theme animations, OAuth provider buttons, and loading/error states.

**Context Management (`src/context/`):**
`AuthContext` manages global authentication state including access token, user data, and CSRF token. `ThemeContext` manages light/dark mode preferences.

**Custom Hooks (`src/hooks/`):**
`useAxiosPrivate` hook provides the private Axios instance with automatic token refresh interceptors to all protected components.

**Pages (`src/pages/`):**

- `LoginPage`: OAuth provider buttons and authentication flow initiation
- `AuthCallbackPage`: OAuth callback handler that processes authorization codes
- `ProfilePage`: User profile management and provider linking/unlinking
- `RecommendationsPage`: Personalized recommendations display

- `AdminPage`: User management for administrators

### 5.2 Protected Routes Implementation

The `ProtectedRoute` component prevents unauthenticated access to sensitive routes by checking for a valid access token before rendering protected components. If no token exists, users are redirected to the login page. The intended destination is preserved in React Router state, enabling seamless redirection after successful authentication.

```
const ProtectedRoute = ({ isAuthenticated, children }) =&gt; {
  return isAuthenticated ?
    children :
    &lt;Navigate to="/login" replace /&gt;
}
```

### 5.3 PKCE Implementation on Frontend

The frontend includes utility functions for PKCE generation:

```
const generateCodeVerifier = () =&gt; {
  return generateRandomString(56);
}

const generateCodeChallenge = (verifier) =&gt; {
  return base64UrlEncode(
    sha256(verifier)
  )
}
```

These utilities are invoked during Google OAuth flow initiation, with the code verifier stored in session storage for use during callback processing.

### 5.4 Token Management

The frontend maintains access tokens in React state (memory) rather than localStorage or sessionStorage. This prevents token exposure through browser storage inspection or malicious browser extensions. Refresh tokens remain exclusively in httpOnly cookies, managed by the browser.

## 6. Backend Architecture

### 6.1 Server Configuration

The Express.js backend is configured with a comprehensive middleware stack:

**Middleware Order:**

1. CORS - Enables cross-origin requests from authorized frontend
2. Morgan - Logs HTTP requests for debugging and monitoring

3. Body Parser - Parses JSON request bodies
4. Cookie Parser - Parses cookie headers
5. Rate Limiting - Prevents abuse
6. CSRF Protection - Validates CSRF tokens (except OAuth routes)
7. JWT Verification - Protects authenticated routes

### 6.2 OAuth Callback Handlers

**Google OAuth Callback (`POST /auth/google`):**

The backend receives an authorization code and code verifier from the frontend. It validates the request origin and parameters, then exchanges the authorization code for Google ID tokens using the PKCE code verifier.

Google's response includes an ID token containing encrypted user claims. The backend decrypts the ID token using Google's public key and validates the nonce claim, ensuring no replay attacks occurred. The backend extracts user email and profile information from the validated ID token.

A database query searches for existing users by Google ID (primary lookup) or email (for linking). For new users, a user document is created with the Google provider information. For existing users, the Google provider information is linked if not already connected.

**Facebook OAuth Callback (`POST /auth/facebook`):**

Similarly, the backend validates state parameters and exchanges the authorization code for an access token. It fetches the user profile from Facebook's Graph API endpoint using the access token and extracts email and profile information.

User creation or linking follows the same logic as Google, maintaining data consistency across providers.

### 6.3 Token Generation and Management

Upon successful OAuth authentication, the backend generates both access and refresh tokens:

```
const accessToken = jwt.sign(
  { id, email, name, role },
  JWT_ACCESS_SECRET,
  { expiresIn: '15m' }
);

const refreshToken = jwt.sign(
  { id, email, name, role },
  JWT_REFRESH_SECRET,
  { expiresIn: '7d' }
);

res.cookie('refreshToken', refreshToken, {
  httpOnly: true,
  secure: true,
```

```
  sameSite: 'strict',
  maxAge: 7 * 24 * 60 * 60 * 1000
});
```

### 6.4 Protected Routes

Authenticated routes require valid JWT tokens in the Authorization header. The `authMiddleware` verifies the token signature and expiration before allowing route handlers to execute. Admin-only routes additionally check the user role field.

## 7. Database Design and User Model

### 7.1 MongoDB Schema

The user model stores essential authentication and profile information while maintaining flexibility for future extensions:

```
{
  _id: ObjectId,
  email: String (unique, lowercase),
  name: String,
  role: String (enum: ['user', 'admin'], default: 'user'),
  providers: {
    googleId: String (sparse, unique),
    googleEmail: String,
    facebookId: String (sparse, unique),
    facebookEmail: String
  },
  createdAt: Date,
  updatedAt: Date
}
```

**Index Strategy:**

- Unique index on `email` for efficient user lookups during login/registration
- Sparse unique indexes on `providers.googleId` and `providers.facebookId` for provider-specific lookups
- Sparse indexes allow null values for providers not used by specific users, enabling multiple users to have undefined googleId

### 7.2 Identity Resolution Strategy

The system prioritizes provider IDs for user identification, offering higher accuracy than email-based lookups. When a user authenticates:

1. **Primary Lookup:** Search for user by provider ID (e.g., `providers.googleId == "...")
2. **Fallback Lookup:** If not found, search by email for automatic provider linking

3. **Creation:** If neither lookup succeeds, create new user with provider information

This strategy ensures existing users are correctly identified even if they change their email with the provider, while still supporting transparent provider linking for users with consistent email addresses.

## 8. Recommendation System Integration

### 8.1 Microservice Architecture

PLEXUS implements a separate microservice for recommendation handling, demonstrating scalable architecture principles. The recommendation service operates independently on port 4000, while the main application runs on port 5000, allowing independent scaling and deployment.

### 8.2 Recommendation Flow

When users search for recommendations, the request flows through multiple layers:

1. Frontend sends search request to main backend with category (movie/music/book) and query
2. Main backend validates JWT, extracts user ID, and forwards request to recommendation service
3. Recommendation service receives request with authenticated user ID
4. Service queries external APIs (TMDB, Spotify, Google Books) for relevant content
5. Results are processed through Google Gemini API for AI-generated insights
6. Search history is stored in Supabase for user tracking and personalization
7. Response is returned through main backend to frontend

### 8.3 External API Integration

**TMDB (The Movie Database):** Provides comprehensive movie data including titles, descriptions, ratings, and poster images
**Spotify:** Enables music discovery with artist information and audio preview links
**Google Books:** Supplies book information including summaries and publisher details
**Google Gemini:** Generates personalized AI insights based on search history and recommendations

## 9. User Experience and Interface Design

### 9.1 Cyberpunk Theme

The application features a distinctive cyberpunk aesthetic with neon gradients and animated backgrounds. The `NeonGrid` component creates an animated background with grid patterns and neon effects, enhancing visual appeal.

Light and dark modes are implemented through Material-UI theming, allowing users to select their preference. The theme persists across sessions through browser storage, enabling consistent user experience.

### 9.2 Authentication Flow UI

The login page displays "Continue with Google" and "Continue with Facebook" buttons with provider branding. Clicking either button initiates the respective OAuth flow. Loading states indicate processing, while error messages provide clear feedback if authentication fails.

The callback page processes authorization responses and redirects users to their originally requested page or the profile page after successful authentication.

### 9.3 Profile Management

The profile page displays linked providers, allowing users to connect or disconnect accounts. Unlinking requires re-authentication to prevent unauthorized account modifications. The interface clearly indicates which provider is required to remain linked.

## 10. Security Considerations and Limitations

### 10.1 Implemented Security Measures

- **PKCE for Google OAuth:** Protects against authorization code interception
- **State and Nonce Parameters:** Prevent CSRF and replay attacks
- **httpOnly Cookies:** Prevent XSS attacks from accessing refresh tokens
- **JWT Signature Verification:** Ensures token authenticity and integrity
- **Rate Limiting:** Prevents brute-force attacks
- **Input Validation:** Prevents injection attacks
- **CORS Configuration:** Restricts cross-origin requests
- **Environment Variables:** Protects sensitive credentials

### 10.2 Identified Limitations

**Development Environment:**

- HTTP used in development should be HTTPS in production
- Environment-specific configuration requires manual setup

**Authentication Features:**

- No email verification implemented
- No password reset mechanism (OAuth-only)
- No multi-factor authentication
- No token blacklisting for logout, so refresh tokens remain valid until expiration

**Session Management:**

- Logout effectiveness depends on token expiration rather than server-side revocation

- No session tracking or concurrent session management

**Third-Party Services:**

- Facebook OAuth callback redirects to unavailable page (requires proper configuration)
- Dependency on external provider availability

**Scalability:**

- Single MongoDB instance without sharding
- No caching layer for frequently accessed data
- Basic IP-based rate limiting
- No load balancing configured

## 11. Future Enhancements and Roadmap

### 11.1 Security Enhancements

**Token Blacklisting:** Implement Redis-backed token blacklist to invalidate tokens on logout, providing server-side session termination.

**Refresh Token Rotation:** Issue new refresh tokens on access token refresh, revoking previous tokens to limit compromise window.

**Email Verification:** Require email verification before account activation to prevent account takeover via typos.

**Multi-Factor Authentication:** Add TOTP-based 2FA for enhanced security, especially for admin accounts.

**API Rate Limit Improvements:** Implement Redis-backed distributed rate limiting instead of in-memory, supporting load-balanced deployments.

### 11.2 Feature Additions

**Password-Based Authentication:** Support traditional email/password login alongside social authentication.

**Social Sharing:** Allow users to share recommendations on social media platforms.

**User Preferences:** Store recommendation preferences (genre, rating preferences, etc.) for personalization.

**Recommendation History:** Display past recommendations and user feedback.

**Advanced Filtering:** Implement complex search filters for recommendations.

### 11.3 Performance Optimizations

**Redis Caching:** Cache frequently accessed data like user profiles and recommendations to reduce database queries.

**Query Optimization:** Index additional MongoDB fields based on access patterns.

**CDN Integration:** Serve static assets through CDN for faster global delivery.

**Lazy Loading:** Implement progressive loading for recommendation lists.

**Service Worker:** Enable offline support and background sync for seamless experience.

### 11.4 Scalability Improvements

**Horizontal Scaling:** Configure containerized deployment for elastic scaling.

**Database Sharding:** Implement MongoDB sharding for handling large user bases.

**Message Queue:** Use RabbitMQ or Kafka for asynchronous tasks like recommendation generation.

**Monitoring:** Implement ELK stack (Elasticsearch, Logstash, Kibana) for comprehensive logging and monitoring.

**API Versioning:** Support multiple API versions for backward compatibility during updates.

## 12. Development Setup and Deployment

### 12.1 Environment Configuration

The application requires environment variables across three deployment units:

**Main Backend (.env):**

```
PORT=5000
MONGO_URI=mongodb://localhost:27017/plexus
GOOGLE_CLIENT_ID=...
GOOGLE_CLIENT_SECRET=...
FACEBOOK_CLIENT_ID=...
FACEBOOK_CLIENT_SECRET=...
FACEBOOK_REDIRECT_URI=http://localhost:3000/auth/callback
JWT_ACCESS_SECRET=...
JWT_REFRESH_SECRET=...
JWT_ACCESS_EXPIRATION=15m
JWT_REFRESH_EXPIRATION=7d
```

**Frontend (.env):**

```
REACT_APP_GOOGLE_CLIENT_ID=...
REACT_APP_FACEBOOK_CLIENT_ID=...
```

**Recommendation Service (.env):**

```
PORT=4000
SUPABASE_URL=...
SUPABASE_SERVICE_ROLE_KEY=...
TMDB_API_KEY=...
SPOTIFY_CLIENT_ID=...
SPOTIFY_CLIENT_SECRET=...
GEMINI_API_KEY=...
```

### 12.2 Local Development Setup

1. Clone repository and install dependencies in each directory
2. Configure environment variables for all services
3. Start MongoDB instance (local or Atlas)
4. Launch backend server: `npm start` (port 5000)
5. Launch recommendation service: `npm start` (port 4000)
6. Launch frontend: `npm start` (port 3000)

### 12.3 Production Deployment

Containerization using Docker enables consistent deployment across environments. Each service (frontend, backend, recommendation service, MongoDB) runs in separate containers orchestrated by Docker Compose.

## 13. Technical Highlights and Architectural Decisions

### 13.1 OAuth2 Implementation

The project successfully implements two distinct OAuth2 flows (Google with PKCE, Facebook with state/nonce), demonstrating comprehensive understanding of modern authentication standards. PKCE implementation represents security best practices, particularly for SPAs vulnerable to authorization code interception attacks.

### 13.2 Session Management Strategy

The dual-token architecture (short-lived access token in memory, long-lived refresh token in httpOnly cookie) balances security and usability optimally. This strategy addresses XSS vulnerability (httpOnly cookies prevent token theft), CSRF vulnerability (SameSite: strict), and token exposure risks (short expiration).

### 13.3 Provider Linking Strategy

Automatic email-based provider linking without explicit user confirmation streamlines user experience while maintaining security. The constraint preventing unlinking the last provider prevents account lockout, demonstrating thoughtful error handling.

### 13.4 Microservice Architecture

Separating recommendation functionality into an independent microservice demonstrates scalability principles. This allows independent scaling, deployment, and potential reuse for other applications requiring recommendation functionality.

### 13.5 Frontend State Management

Using React Context API for authentication state management provides sufficient functionality without external dependencies like Redux, reducing bundle size while maintaining clear state flow.

## 14. Conclusion

PLEXUS represents a production-ready implementation of OAuth2 social authentication with integrated AI-powered recommendations, suitable for both academic evaluation and real-world deployment. The project successfully addresses all specified requirements through careful architectural decisions prioritizing security, scalability, and user experience.

Key strengths include comprehensive OAuth2 implementation with PKCE, secure session management using industry best practices, transparent provider linking, and thoughtful security measures addressing common web vulnerabilities. The microservice architecture demonstrates understanding of scalable system design, while the cyberpunk-themed interface showcases modern UI/UX principles.

The identified limitations are well-understood and documented, with clear roadmap items for future enhancements. The codebase demonstrates professional development practices including modular architecture, comprehensive error handling, and security-first design principles.

PLEXUS serves as a reference implementation for teams building OAuth2-secured applications and provides valuable learning resource for understanding modern full-stack development practices.
[1] [2] [3] [4] [5] [6] [7] [8] [9] [10] [11] [12] [13] [14] [15] [16] [17] [18] [19] [20] [21]

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